mid-March 2015 in each of the major states/regions in Myanmar. No replacements had to be made to the thirty-six randomly selected sample points, and the team was fortunate to avoid tensions and fighting in some states/regions with early fieldwork implementation. A total of 1,620 people were surveyed in face-to-face interviews. These interviews took an average of an hour-and-fifteen minutes per respondent. YSPS staff were trained and advised by the ABS team from May 2014 through to the end of the survey in March 2015. The national survey was conducted after a successful pilot survey of 720 respondents during September–October 2014 in Bago. The survey was conducted in Burmese, and in the ethnic minority areas with interpreters in local languages.[6] The survey was carried out with the permission of national and state government authorities, and with the knowledge and cooperation of local township officials. While there were a few minor misunderstandings in the fieldwork with local government officials, the relationship with the government was cordial, as officials facilitated the implementation of an independent national survey. The main challenges in the field included logistical access to locations (as a result of poor transportation infrastructure) and difficult physical conditions, especially in more remote areas such as the Chin State.

As public surveys are a relatively new phenomenon in Myanmar,[7] and the historical record with them, as occurred after the 1990 election, is chequered, another challenge involved public confidence and interaction. There were comprehension issues on some of the questions, particularly among less educated and more remote, less exposed respondents. Significant efforts were made to improve comprehension and question wording during the survey, but there were understandable gaps. Some of the more complicated questions solicited more "don't knows". Given general concerns about the political climate and authoritarian history of Myanmar, the response rate for the ABS survey was very high. It reached seventy-five per cent, with interviewers reporting positive cooperation from the majority of respondents. This shows the viability of seeking public views in Myanmar. The results do indicate, however, that fear and reserve were present, especially with regard to sensitive political questions, as there were higher rates of non-answers to sensitive questions. Cross-regional comparisons with other ABS data show that Myanmar citizens were no less inclined to answer sensitive questions than other countries, especially those in Southeast Asia such as Cambodia, Vietnam, and Malaysia. In fact, on some questions, there were more responses than in other countries,